

Vendor Proposal Comparison Matrix

Ardent ISD | Wireless Modernization Review

Purpose

This matrix helps district leadership compare vendor proposals using common criteria rather than purchase price alone. Technical scoring should be completed with qualified network staff; procurement and E-Rate requirements should be reviewed separately.

Criterion	NorthStar Networks	CivicWave Systems	Lone Peak Technology
5-year estimated district cost	\$232,400	\$219,800	\$246,100
Access point quantity	172	164	180
Switch upgrades included	Partial	Yes	Yes
Cabling allowance	\$20,000 allowance	Included up to stated scope	Not included
Management/licensing	5 years included	3 years included; years 4-5 extra	5 years included
Installation validation	Predictive design + post-install survey	Predictive design only	Predictive + sample post-install validation
Training	2 admin sessions	1 admin session	4 admin sessions + handoff guide
Warranty/support	Standard manufacturer warranty	Enhanced support for 3 years	Enhanced support for 5 years
E-Rate language	Vendor notes possible eligibility; district must verify	Proposal separates potentially eligible items	No eligibility assumptions stated
Key concern	Cabling allowance may be insufficient	Years 4-5 licensing not in headline price	Highest cost and cabling excluded

Weighted Leadership Criteria

Criterion	Weight	Why It Matters
Technical fit and scalability	25%	Solution must meet present density and future growth assumptions.
Lifecycle cost	20%	Licensing, maintenance, support, and replacement timing affect sustainability.
Implementation risk	15%	School calendars, testing windows, facilities access, and cutover risk matter.
Supportability	15%	District staff must be able to monitor, troubleshoot, and maintain the environment.
Interoperability	10%	New infrastructure must integrate with existing switching, authentication, filtering, and monitoring.
Vendor support and handoff	10%	Documentation, escalation, training, and post-install support reduce operational risk.
Procurement/E-Rate readiness	5%	Proposal structure should support district review and documentation requirements.

Questions Before Selection

1. What assumptions are being made about cabling, electrical power, ceiling access, and MDF/IDF readiness?
2. Which recurring licenses or support costs begin after the initial term?
3. What equipment becomes district property, and what remains subscription-dependent?
4. What post-install validation will demonstrate that the design solved the documented problem?
5. What are the lead times, change-order conditions, and escalation paths?
6. What current E-Rate rules apply to each line item?

Recommendation Process

Do not select solely from this matrix. Use it to identify finalists, resolve unanswered questions, validate technical claims, complete procurement review, and document the rationale for the final decision.

Reference Points

- [CoSN IT Management Resources](#) - K-12 technology operations and leadership resources.
- [USAC E-Rate Program](#) - Federal E-Rate program information for schools and libraries.
- [SETDA Infrastructure for the Future](#) - Guidance for future-ready broadband and infrastructure planning.
- [Future Ready Schools Frameworks](#) - Systems-oriented planning connecting infrastructure, learning, leadership, budget, and equity.

Leadership use: This document is designed to support district-level review, discussion, and decision-making. Technical validation, procurement review, legal review, or compliance review should be completed by the appropriate district specialists when applicable.